

UNIT 3 · LESSON 1

Conflict As Information

45–50 min · January Week 1 · Standard

OBJECTIVE	Students distinguish conflict as data from conflict as threat, identify their dominant conflict pattern, and apply the conflict-as-data reframe to one current situation.
CASEL FOCUS	Social Awareness (primary) · Relationship Skills (supporting)
DURATION	45–50 min · January Week 1 · Standard
KEY VOCABULARY	conflict as data · conflict as threat · fight · flight · freeze · fawn · unmet need · values friction
MATERIALS	Journals · Anchor chart · Scenario Cards B4-15A, B4-15B · WS B4-U3-WS1 (Conflict Pattern)
OPENING REVIEW	'Unit 2 ended with the Backpack Audit. Today Unit 3 begins. The question shifts outward: what do I do with the people who have hurt me — and with the people I have hurt? Today: what is conflict actually trying to tell you?'

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES 9–10 · EARLY HIGH SCHOOL

Goal 2 — Social Awareness & Interpersonal Skills**2D.4a** Analyze how listening and talking accurately help in resolving conflicts.**2A.4a** Analyze similarities and differences between one's own and others' perspectives.*Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).*

ANCHOR CHART

WHAT CONFLICT SIGNALS A
VALUE HAS BEEN CROSSED
A NEED HAS NOT BEEN MET
A BOUNDARY HAS BEEN
IGNORED A TRUTH NEEDS
NAMING

WHAT CONFLICT IS NOT
EVIDENCE OF FAILURE
SOMETHING TO ALWAYS
AVOID PROOF SOMEONE IS
WRONG A THREAT — IT IS
INFORMATION

OPENING RITUAL

60–90 seconds 'Both feet on the floor. One breath slower than usual.' [Pause 10 seconds.] 'Unit 3 begins today. The question turns outward. Not what do I do with the voice inside that judges me — what do I do with the people who have hurt me, and the people I have hurt, without losing myself in either direction? Today we start with the basics: what is conflict actually trying to tell you?' [Post: 'What is the conflict in your life right now trying to tell you — if you listened to it as data?']

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During Step 2, a student who marks FAWN as dominant across every context — family, friendships, school, relationships — without variation.

MAY SIGNAL Pervasive fawning is a survival pattern, often developed in response to high-consequence adult conflict. Not a relationship skill deficit.

ACTION Note privately. Monitor through L3 (Boundary of Peace) — brief counselor before L3 if pattern appears across multiple students. |

IN-LESSON SCAN

OBSERVE During Step 3, a student who cannot name a single relationship where they respond to conflict — who describes avoiding all conflict entirely.

MAY SIGNAL Total conflict avoidance may indicate significant anxiety about relational disruption, or an environment where conflict has historically been unsafe.

ACTION After class: 'Conflict feels like something to stay away from entirely for you — that makes sense. I'd like to talk more about it at some point.' Plant the door without pressing. |

SCENARIO CARDS · FACILITATION NOTES

B4-15A and B4-15B B4-15A (NIA AND HER MOM): Whole-class. Key: 'What is this conflict signaling as data? Which pattern is Nia using — and what is it costing her?' B4-15B (DARIUS AND THE GROUP PROJECT): Pairs. Key: 'Darius freezes. What does he lose — and what would responding differently have looked like?'

GRADE-BAND DIFFERENTIATION

GRADES 9 · 10	GRADES 11 · 12
Grades 9–10: Keep pattern identification behavioral. The Conflict Pattern Worksheet	Grades 11–12: Connect to adult/professional contexts — 'The fawn pattern that kept you safe in

grounds the insight. Do not push for philosophical abstraction.

high school may make you invisible in a professional context. What would you need to believe about yourself to respond differently?' Connects to B5-U3-L2.

EXIT TICKET

"My dominant conflict pattern is _____. The context where it costs me the most is _____. If I read the conflict in that context as data, the signal it is sending is _____." Journal — private. Never collected. Never graded.

TEACHER REFLECTION

The FAWN pattern is the most common dominant pattern among students who have developed strong social performance muscles — they are often rewarded for it and don't recognize it as a pattern. Name it carefully: 'Fawning is not kindness. It is what happens when keeping the peace feels safer than saying what is true.' Before L3 — brief counselor on any students who marked FAWN dominant across all contexts.

FAMILY CONNECTION · CONVERSATION STARTER

L1 Today students began Unit 3 — Conflict and Context. They examined what conflict is actually trying to tell us when we read it as data rather than threat, and identified their dominant conflict pattern — fight, flight, freeze, or fawn. Conversation-starter: 'When conflict comes up in our family, what do you tend to do — and do you think it works?'

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

Scripted teaching sequence · Steps 1 — 3 · read aloud or in your own words

01 CONFLICT AS DATA — THE REFRAME

8 MIN

'Most of us treat conflict as a threat — something to win, flee, or survive. But conflict is almost always carrying information: something matters here that is not being met.' Write: CONFLICT = signal that something matters AND something is misaligned. 'When Nia and her mom fight about the same thing for

the fifth time, the fight is not the problem. The fight is the signal.' Ask: 'What is the conflict in your life right now — read as data rather than threat — trying to tell you?' 2 minutes journal. Private.

02 THE FOUR DOMINANT PATTERNS

10 MIN

Post the four patterns. 'Everyone has a dominant pattern — the default response when conflict arises. It developed for a reason.' Distribute WS B4-U3-WS1 (Conflict Pattern). Walk through all four patterns with specific behavioral descriptions. 4 minutes private — mark dominant pattern across four contexts.

03 THE COST OF EACH PATTERN

7 MIN

'Every pattern has a cost. FIGHT: win the argument, lose the relationship. FLIGHT: conflict ends, issue remains, goes in the backpack. FREEZE: present but absent. FAWN: keep the peace, lose your position.'

Pairs: 'Name one relationship where your dominant pattern is costing you something specific. What would it cost you to respond differently — just once?'

SCENARIO CARDS

Print and laminate before unit. Two cards per lesson.

B4-15A THE 24-HOUR RULE

THE SITUATION

After a group project meeting dissolved into conflict — disagreements about workload, accusations about effort, raised voices — Marcus sent three texts in rapid succession that he immediately regretted. By the next morning, the messages had been screenshot and shared. What started as a conflict between four people was now a social situation involving fifteen. Marcus's first three sentences destroyed what three months of relationship had built.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

What happened in the gap between Marcus's emotional flooding and his first text — and what was missing there? Marcus's texts may have been accurate — he may have had genuine grievances. Does accuracy make the timing right? The 24-hour rule does not say 'never say the hard thing.' What does it say — and why does the distinction matter? Redesign Marcus's approach: what does a response (not a reaction) look like for this situation?

RESPONSE VS. REACTION A *reaction is immediate, emotion-driven, and often accurate in content and wrong in timing. A response is deliberate — it contains the same honest content delivered after the emotional flooding has subsided. The 24-hour rule is not about suppressing what needs to be said. It is about choosing when to say it in a way that the other person can actually hear.*

B 4 - 15 B THE 24-HOUR RULE

THE SITUATION

Nia received feedback from a teacher on an essay she had worked hard on. The feedback was detailed and included several significant criticisms. Nia's first impulse was to go to the teacher that period and explain why every criticism was wrong. She stopped herself. She waited until the next day. When she returned, she had three genuine questions and one point of respectful disagreement. The conversation was productive. Her teacher raised her grade.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

What changed between Nia's first impulse and the next-day conversation? Nia still had a point of disagreement on day two — the 24-hour rule didn't make her opinion change. What did it change? What would have happened if Nia had followed her first impulse — and what would she not have been able to hear? Identify a recent situation where you reacted instead of responding. What would a 24-hour pause have changed?

THE WINDOW OF DELIBERATION *Emotional flooding impairs the prefrontal cortex — the part of the brain responsible for deliberate reasoning and long-term consequence evaluation. The 24-hour rule creates a window in which that capacity returns. During that window, honest disagreement becomes possible without the content being filtered through someone else's defensiveness. The goal is not to manufacture agreement — it is to create conditions where honest exchange can actually happen.*

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 4 · THE FAÇADE (9–10)

What Conflict Is — and Is Not

Unit 3

REPAIR

WHAT CONFLICT SIGNALS

- A value has been crossed
- A need has not been met
- A boundary has been ignored
- A truth needs naming

WHAT CONFLICT IS NOT

- Evidence of failure
- Something to always avoid
- Proof someone is wrong
- A threat

Conflict is not a threat. It is information.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 4 · The Façade (9–10)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

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